

Why Pakistan Disrupts While China Infiltrates: Rivalry Structure and Divergent Subversion Against India

Aditya Sudhir Nakadi

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1 Abstract

This essay develops an explanation for why Pakistan and China have adopted structurally different forms of subversion against India using structured comparison and process tracing of cyber-threat reports, policy documents, and investigative journalism. Results indicate that it is rivalry type and not regime type, capability, or alliance that determines the subversion strategy. Existential rivalry consistently produces high-threat perception and high risk tolerance for overt, disruptive subversion in the case of Pakistan. For China, positional rivalry has produced moderate threat perception and risk-averse behavior, leading to a strategy of covert, intelligence-driven subversion. The findings have significant implications for how states should respond to qualitatively different subversion threats.

2 Introduction

Subversion, whether covert, indirect or plausibly deniable state behavior intended to shape an adversary's political environment, has become a defining feature of contemporary interstate

rivalry, in part due to the cost-cutting effects of cyber capabilities (Buchanan 2016; Valeriano and Maness 2015). Thomas Rid describes cyber operations as essentially contemporary reinterpretations of espionage, sabotage, and subversion, not war (Rid 2013). Likewise, most cyber interactions between states remain, as shown by Valeriano and Maness, primarily driven by traditional notions of signaling, intelligence gathering, and messaging (Valeriano and Maness 2015).

India provides a rich comparative environment. It confronts two of its long-standing rivals, Pakistan and China, which wage influence operations, cyber activity, and informational pressure, but their techniques are different. The subversion by Pakistan is usually overt: militant proxies, aggressive disinformation, harassment. In comparison, China’s subversion is gradual: intelligence-oriented cyber espionage, infrastructure probing, and technological leverage.

This variation prompts the following central question that this essay aims to answer: ***Why do Pakistan and China, two strategic partners, and long-standing rivals of India, use such different forms of subversion towards it?***

This essay argues that rivalry type is the most powerful explanation. Drawing on rivalry theory, which differentiates existential from positional rivalries (Colaresi et al. 2007; Diehl and Goertz 2000), this essay demonstrates that Pakistan’s rivalry with India is existential, anchored in identity conflict, the trauma of Partition, and the ideological significance of Kashmir (Fair 2014; Ganguly 1997). China’s rivalry with India is positional, driven by long-term competition for influence, border management, and strategic space rather than survival (Scobell et al. 2018; Tellis 2020).

To trace how rivalry structure shapes subversive style, the essay develops a six-step causal mechanism: ***rivalry type → perceived stakes → threat perception → strategic objectives → cost-benefit calculus → risk tolerance → mode of subversion***. This essay aims to evaluate this mechanism using structured comparison and process tracing, drawing on threat intelligence reports, investigative journalism, and policy documents. Al-

ternative explanations, such as regime type, material capabilities, and external alignment, are evaluated and shown to have less explanatory value than rivalry structure.

3 Conceptual and Theoretical Framework

3.1 Subversion as Covert Statecraft

Subversion is defined as the indirect or clandestine actions undertaken by the state that seek to affect political outcomes, perceptions, or processes within the target country. Subversion, as a form of non-violent coercion, operates by exploiting political, psychological, and institutional weaknesses within the society (Maschmeyer 2022). Likewise, every aspect of clandestine activity must balance concealment, efficiency, and detection (O’Rourke 2018). Some may be ready to incur costs in terms of reputation or foreign policy for strategic motives, whereas others prioritize maintaining deniability.

Domestic political frameworks establish the opportunity structure, specific weaknesses enemies can exploit (Ganguly 1997). However, rivalry structure explains adversary choices regarding the use of modalities of subversion, as well as the degree of risk.

3.2 Cyber Operations as Subversion

Cyber operations are now central instruments of subversion (Rid 2013). Three critical insights can be derived from literature that revolves around cyber wars: **(1)** cyber-based operations remain limited and focused more on messaging as opposed to destructive capabilities (Valeriano and Maness 2015); **(2)** cyber-based capabilities proliferate rapidly, thereby increasing the vulnerability of the originating force’s own capabilities (Buchanan 2016); **(3)** cyber-based tools of subversion remain more linked to information, as opposed to physical effects (Gartzke 2013). Indeed, cyber-based forms of subversion remain selected for political and strategic reasoning as opposed to mere capabilities.

3.3 Rivalry Theory: Structural Logic

Rivalry theory explains persistent adversarial relationships characterized by repeated militarized interaction and enduring threat perceptions (Diehl and Goertz 2000). This essay builds on rivalry theory to distinguish two analytically sound types of rivalry: existential and positional. It builds on the formative research by Colaresi, Rasler, and Thompson (2007) on how rivalries structure threat perceptions and expectations of conflict. According to this view, existential rivalries will be rooted in identity and perceived threats to state survival, while positional rivalries are driven by competition over influence, power, and status.

The Kashmir dispute with Pakistan, along with its historical experiences, is situated within the context of its existential rivalry (Fair 2014; Ganguly 1997). On the contrary, China views India as a rival for strategic status, but not as an existential threat (Scobell et al. 2018; Tellis 2020). Rivalry structure conditions the type of subversion a state finds strategically rational by shaping both the perceived stakes and tolerable levels of operational risk.

3.4 Causal Mechanism and Method

The mechanism linking rivalry type to subversion strategy proceeds in six steps:

- Rivalry type (existential vs. positional)**
- **perceived stakes (survival/identity vs. influence/position)**
- **threat perception (acute vs. moderate)**
- **strategic objectives (destabilization vs. constraint/leverage)**
- **cost–benefit calculus for covert action**
- **risk tolerance (high vs. low)**
- **operational modality (disruptive vs. infiltrative)**

This essay applies the structured comparison and process-tracing methodology (George and Bennett 2005) to examine this causal mechanism within the relationship dynamics of

Pakistan/India and China/India, using threat intelligence reporting as its empirical component.

4 Pakistan’s Logic of Subversion

Pakistan’s subversive posture against India can be best understood as an existential rivalry, fraught with identity struggles, territorial disputes, and security narratives.

4.1 Rivalry Origins and Threat Perception

The Indo-Pak rivalry is enshrined in the trauma of Partition and the centrality of Kashmir to Pakistan’s state identity. Fair catalogs how Pakistan’s military strategic culture frames India as an enduring, identity-level threat embedded in doctrine and training (Fair 2014). Ganguly underlines that Kashmir represents a pivotal position within the Pakistani ideological discourse, since it was envisioned as a homeland for South Asian Muslims (Ganguly 1997); therefore, the classification of Kashmir as disputed represents an integral element in maintaining the ideological coherence of the nation. These perceptions within the Pakistani establishment are further exacerbated by the disproportionate civil-military balance, with the army’s threat perceptions driving national security decision-making (Abbasi 2020).

4.2 Strategic Objectives and Instruments

This existential framing produces three strategic objectives: **(1)** destabilizing Indian control in Kashmir through proxies and political agitation; **(2)** delegitimizing India domestically and internationally by amplifying human-rights and communal narratives; and **(3)** imposing costs on India below the threshold of interstate war through asymmetric tools (Ganguly and Kapur 2010; Fair 2014).

Pakistan’s toolkit spans physical proxies to information operations to cyber activity. Proxy groups like Lashkar-e-Taiba and Jaish-e-Mohammed have been used historically to

inflict asymmetric costs on India (Ganguly and Kapur 2010; Fair 2014). In the information sphere, platform transparency reports and independent media investigations report on the takedown of networks that companies estimated as engaging in coordinated inauthentic behavior emanating from Pakistan, without claiming state command responsibility (Reuters 2020; Meta Platforms Inc. 2020).

In cyber operations, cybersecurity firm Zscaler ThreatLabz reports that APT-36 (also known as Transparent Tribe) has conducted advanced phishing, malvertising (trojanised MFA apps), and credential-harvesting campaigns against Indian government organizations (Singh 2022).

4.3 Process Trace: Pulwama (February 2019)

The Pulwama attack indicates how Pakistan’s existential rivalry translates into subversion patterns. On 14 February 2019, there was a suicide bombing that killed Indian paramilitary personnel. Three observable elements could be seen in the immediate aftermath: **(1)** kinetic proxy violence; **(2)** an increase in social-media manipulation activities, and platform takedowns for coordinated inauthentic behavior, according to Meta and Reuters; and **(3)** increased phishing and credential-harvesting operations against Indian defense entities, which were assessed by private cybersecurity firms, not by the Indian government, as linked to Pakistan-attributed clusters (Singh 2022).

4.4 Cost Tolerance and Risk Acceptance

Pakistan’s strategic culture reveals a notable inclination to endure reputational and economic costs when actions are framed as necessary for defending identity or core strategic objectives. The FATF greylisting from 2018 to 2022 identified weaknesses in Pakistan’s AML/CFT regime but did not attribute proxy support (FATF 2018; FATF 2018). Analysts, however, contend that the continued use of proxies and ongoing information networks show that Pakistan is willing to incur external costs on behalf of perceived existential objectives (Fair,

2014). Existential rivalry, in effect, produces identity-laden stakes and a strategic calculus that accepts diplomatic and economic risks and escalation risks to maintain pressure on India.

While the **alternative explanations** of regime type, availability of militant groups, or resource asymmetry illuminate Pakistan’s capacity for subversion, it does not match its typical style. While a regime with strong military and strategic prowess may enable covert operations, China possesses those attributes without resorting to noisy, escalatory tactics. An authoritarian-leaning regime with a powerful military may enable covert action, but China shares those attributes without resorting to noisy, escalatory tactics. While material weakness may incentivize asymmetric tools, it cannot account for Pakistan’s tolerance of consistently high diplomatic and economic costs. Nor can opportunistic access to militants explain why those proxies are used in such a way as to invite routine international scrutiny. Only the existential character of the rivalry explains why Pakistan would be consistently willing to absorb high risks and high visibility in service to identity-linked objectives.

5 China’s Logic of Subversion

At the strategic level, the subversive policies of China against India depict positional rivalry, a contest for status, influence, and strategic space.

5.1 Rivalry Type and Threat Perception

Chinese analyses tend to view India as a regional competitor, not an existential threat (Scobell et al. 2018). The incidents along the border, for example, that were witnessed in Doklam in 2017 and Galwan Valley in 2020 are seen as instruments of management of strategic position, rather than as expressions of oppositional identity (Tellis 2020). It is clear that the rapport between India, the United States, Japan, and Australia under the QUAD is perceived by China as challenging its regional influence and strategic positioning,

perpetually reinforcing the positional rivalry that operates to illustrate competition and cost management rather than survival.

5.2 Strategic Objectives and Instruments

Within this rivalry structure, China’s goals focus on long-term intelligence advantage, strategic constraints, controlling narratives, and structural leverage. China seeks persistent access to the Indian military, government, telecommunication, and critical infrastructure to maintain situational awareness, preferring coercive leverage over kinetic action. It also cultivates narratives through propaganda and structural dependencies through technology infrastructure (Brady 2008; ORF 2021)

China’s cyber landscape, as well as its corresponding units within the PLA Strategic Support Force and the Ministry of State Security, and their contracted services, appear to operate with a focus on stealth, persistence, and targeting specific networks. Following this, the activity associated with APT41 was identified as extensive espionage and supply-chain-based intrusions worldwide, extending into Indian sectors (Google Cloud / Mandiant 2020). This fits the pattern of operation that Beijing favors in terms of infiltrative and intelligence-led actions. Following this, subsequent industry reporting identified associated cyber activity in the Indian sphere, specifically targeting the Indian power infrastructure (The Hacker News 2021).

5.3 Process Trace: RedEcho and the LAC Crisis (2020–21)

Following the incident on the Line of Actual Control in 2020–21, Recorded Future’s Insikt Group found that a malicious actor labeled RedEcho was targeting Indian control centers for the electricity industry, as well as their SCADA systems, with the aim of reconnaissance and persistent access, as opposed to destruction (Insikt Group 2021). Soon, this incident was reported in news articles with a focus on the concern displayed by Indians with regard to this persistent surveillance activity (The Hindu 2021; The Hacker News 2021). RedEcho’s

activity, in which they gained access without causing any disruptions, reflects the principles of positional rivalry.

Like most cyber attribution assessments, these results are probabilistic rather than definite answers, but the style or pattern of behavior aligns with positional rivalry logic.

5.4 Cost Sensitivity and Risk Aversion

China’s integration into global trade and finance, combined with the diffusion risks inherent in cyber tools, where exploits may be reverse-engineered or rapidly reused by others (Buchanan 2016), creates incentives for operational caution. Overtly destructive cyber attacks may result in diplomatic backlash, economic sanctions, as well as accelerate India’s strategic alignment with the United States. Consequently, the policy preferences favor covert cyber operations and competition over position and leverage.

Alternative explanations, such as regime type, material capabilities, and external alignment provide only partial accounts of the observed patterns. A regime-type explanation would predict similar subversion styles because both Pakistan and China are non-liberal states with strong security sectors, yet the two behave very differently. A capability-based explanation would predict that China’s far greater cyber capacity should make it more willing to conduct disruptive attacks, but the evidence shows the opposite. An alignment-based explanation would expect Pakistan’s behavior to shift as its external partners changed, yet its disruptive posture has remained consistent across alignment cycles. **In contrast, rivalry type accurately predicts both cases and matches the empirical evidence more closely and more consistently than any alternative.**

6 Comparative Analysis and Alternative Explanations

6.1 Rivalry Structure as the Most Comprehensive Explanation

The rivalry-type mechanism coherently links observed strategies to structural conditions:

1. **Pakistan's rivalry**, focused on its existential threat, produces perceptions that are identity-driven, aimed at destabilization, and accepting of a high level of political and diplomatic risk, resulting in overt disruptive subversion using proxies, disinformation, and noisy cyber harassment.
2. **China's positional rivalry** rivalry establishes long-term objectives for competition and moderate threat perception with low risk tolerance. This can result in spying infrastructure reconnaissance and the creation of dependencies without obvious awareness.

This framework explains why the two adversaries employ qualitatively different subversive tactics, with visible divergence in capacity, regime type, and alliances: Pakistan favors high-visibility tactics, escalatory in nature, while China prefers low-visibility ones that build up intelligence and leverage.

6.2 Evaluating Alternatives

1. **Regime Type:** Pakistan and China are both non-liberal states with strong security institutions; if regime type shaped subversion style, their behavior should converge. Instead, it diverges markedly. Regime type explains capacity, not risk posture (Valeriano and Maness 2015).
2. **Material Capabilities:** China's far superior cyber and intelligence capabilities could support highly disruptive attacks, yet Beijing persistently opts for stealthy espionage. This demonstrates that capability expands options but does not determine strategic choice (Buchanan 2016).

- 3. External Alignment:** Pakistan’s alignment has shifted repeatedly, from U.S.-centric to China-centric, yet its basic subversion pattern remained stable. China’s behavior likewise predates the QUAD’s reinvigoration. Alliances shape opportunities, but not the direction or visibility of subversion.

Collectively, alternative explanations lack directional accuracy, temporal consistency, or explanatory completeness. Rivalry structure, by clarifying how states perceive stakes, threats, and risks, offers the most comprehensive account of why Pakistan disrupts while China infiltrates.

7 Policy Implications

The divergence in subversion styles identified in this analysis requires differentiated defensive strategies. Because existential rivalry often breeds high-profile, escalatory forms of subversion, whereas positional rivalry is intelligence-led and low-profile, a different approach is required for Pakistan than for China.

7.1 Mitigating Pakistan’s Disruptive Subversion:

- 1. Counter-proxy capabilities:** improve border security, expand targeted counterterrorism operations, and disrupt proxy logistics.
- 2. Information resilience:** strengthen platform-government cooperation for rapid identification and takedown of coordinated inauthentic behavior and build strategic communication capabilities to blunt disinformation effects.
- 3. Cost-imposition:** use diplomatic exposure of proxy networks, targeted sanctions where credible, and enforcement that increases the political and economic price of proxy-enabled activities.

7.2 Mitigating China’s Infiltrative Subversion:

1. **Cyber hardening:** embrace strategic investments in SCADA, communications infrastructure, and critical supply chain security, alongside red-team testing.
2. **Supply-chain diversification:** sustained HUMINT and technical collection against long-duration infiltration routes, through partnerships with the domestic industry and foreign intelligence services.
3. **Counterintelligence and threat intelligence:** sustained HUMINT and technical collection against long-duration infiltration routes, through partnerships with the domestic industry and foreign intelligence services.
4. **Strategic narrative competition:** multilateral diplomacy to uncover the covert influence efforts as well as establish normative standards about the security of critical infrastructure.

To treat Pakistan and China as if they posed the same threat of subversion would be inefficient. It would increase the dangers of escalation. An effective defense must differentiate between existential threats, which pose open, disruptive threats, and threats, which pose hidden, persistent intelligence challenges.

8 Limitations and Future Research

Several conditions qualify the findings. First, rivalry structure explains the style of subversion rather than the precise timing of particular operations; leadership choices, crisis dynamics, and bureaucratic politics can introduce variation. Second, the measure of clandestine activity is always problematic; attribution is only probabilistic, disputable, and often dependent on further technological or intelligence revelations (O’Rourke 2018). Third, internal-state bureaucratic struggles and organizational politics within the national security sector are important immediate variables that deserve more micro-analysis. Fourth, rivalry types are

not fixed: positional rivalries can transform into existential, or vice versa, which will shift expectations. Future studies might test the rivalry type paradigm across a broader array of dyads (e.g., Russia and Ukraine, Israel and Iran) and explore the dynamic effects of new technologies (e.g., artificial intelligence, IoT) on the calculations underlying covert action. Additionally, they may also investigate new technologies (AI-powered surveillance, offensive automated capabilities, ubiquitous IoT networks) that may transform the cost-benefit calculations of espionage-based subversive competition.

9 Conclusion

This essay demonstrates that Pakistan and China pursue distinct subversion strategies against India because they inhabit fundamentally different rivalry structures. Pakistan’s existential rivalry produces identity-laden threat perceptions and destabilization objectives as well as high tolerance for risk, yielding overt and disruptive subversion. China’s positional rivalry, in contrast, produces bounded threat perceptions and leverage objectives as well as risk aversion, yielding covert, intelligence-driven subversion. The six-step mechanism developed in this analysis links rivalry type to operational modality. It offers a parsimonious explanation that outcompetes alternatives such as regime type, material capability, or international alignment. The findings here also carry implications for how to design differentiated defensive postures: rapid disruption management and counterproxy capabilities are relevant for Pakistan, and long-term cyber resilience, counterintelligence, and supply chain security are relevant for China. Understanding how the structure of rivalry shapes subversion is thus crucial to analysis and policy alike. Countries facing multiple adversaries must determine the nature of their rivalry, as a mistaken assessment of their threat sources may result in the allocation of insufficient or inefficient capabilities. Structural studies such as this provide insights that can aid more rigorous investigations into how structural properties affect non-war rivalry.

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